unculturable land. The area under non-agricultural use was recorded at 27.08 million hectares, or about 8.8 per cent.

Built-Up Land is Still Much Smaller

Total built-up area—factories, roads, buildings—represent the land used by the non-agricultural economy. According to a satellite-based study titled ‘History of Land Use in India during 1980–2010’, published in the journal *Global and Planetary Change* in 2014, the total area occupied by buildings, roads and railways (all the built-up area) was only 2.04 million hectares—the area under crops was stated to be 140 million hectares in the study. Total built-up area under buildings was less than 0.7 per cent of the country’s reporting land mass.

The Ministry of Agriculture, as we noted above, places about 27 million hectares as ‘area under non-agricultural uses’. The definition of ‘area under non-agricultural uses’ is however much wider than the definition of ‘built-up area’ as it covers lands under rivers, water bodies, parks, social forestry and so on. As the land statistics published by the Ministry of Agriculture do not specifically carve out built-up land, we can assume India’s built-up area is somewhat higher than the 2.04 million hectares confirmed by satellite data—let’s say about 3 million hectares or about 1 per cent of total land area of the country.

Meanwhile, according to the land use statistics published by the Ministry of Agriculture and the satellite imagery-based numbers quoted in the study, agricultural crops occupy about 140 million hectares, which is 45 per cent of reporting land area. Land under cultivation has expanded from about 115 million hectares in 1950. As irrigation facilities have expanded, including double-cropped area, total cropped area is approximately 200 million hectares now.

Agriculture, mining and other directly land-based productive activities contribute only 20 per cent of India’s GDP. The rest of the economy, which